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Andy Phillip, 79, Whiz Kid In College, All-Star in N.B.A.

By Richard Goldstein

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VIEW ON TIMSMACHINE

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Andy Phillip, the Hall of Fame guard who starred in the early 1940's for the University of Illinois basketball teams known as the Whiz Kids and then became a premier playmaker in the N.B.A., died last Saturday at his home in Rancho Mirage, Calif. He was 79.

The cause was congestive heart failure, said his wife, Corky.

A five-time All-Star during his 11-year career in the N.B.A., Phillip was the first player to have at least 500 assists in a season, amassing 539 for the Philadelphia Warriors in 1951-52, and he was a three-time season leader in assists per game. The former Boston Celtics and St. Louis Hawks star Easy Ed Macauley regarded Phillip, together with the Celtics' Bob Cousy and the Knicks' Dick McGuire, as "the three greatest passers in the game."

"His greatest value to the team was his ability to make everybody better," Macauley once said.

The 6-foot-3-inch Phillip, a native of Granite City, Ill., was a two-time all-American at Illinois, helping lead the team to Big Ten championships in 1942 and '43. He was the Big Ten's most valuable player in the 1942-1943 season, when he set conference records for points in a season (255, an average of 21.3 a game) and in a game (40). Those Illinois teams, known as the Whiz Kids for their sophomore and then junior casts, used speed on offense and tenacious defense. "The fast break was our game," Phillip once said. "We were ahead of our time."

The Whiz Kids went off to war after the 1943 season. Phillip served as a lieutenant in the Marine Corps, taking part in the Iwo Jima campaign, and returned to Illinois for the

1946-47 season.

He made his pro debut in 1947-48 with the Chicago Stags of the Basketball Association of America -- the forerunner of the N.B.A. -- and remained with them for three seasons while also playing baseball in the St. Louis Cardinals' minor league system. He played with the Warriors for two seasons and with the Fort Wayne Pistons for four seasons, then seemed ready to retire because of a knee problem.

But Red Auerbach, the Celtics' coach, obtained Phillip to back up Cousy, one of the greatest guards in league history. Playing on a team that had five other future Hall of Famers -- Cousy, Bill Russell, Bill Sharman, Tom Heinsohn and Frank Ramsey -- Phillip helped the Celtics win their first title, in 1957, the outset of a long period of Celtic domination.

He retired after his second season in Boston, with career averages of 9.1 points and 5.4 assists a game. He was inducted into the Basketball Hall of Fame in Springfield, Mass., in 1961.

Phillip coached the St. Louis Hawks briefly in 1958 and the Chicago Majors of the American Basketball League in 1961. He later worked as a probation supervisor in Riverside County, Calif.

In addition to his wife, he is survived by a son, Steven, of Maui, Hawaii; a brother, Robert, of Vero Beach, Fla.; and a step-grandson, Michael Scanlan, of Granite City.

Heinsohn, his Celtics teammate, lauded Phillip for melding his quickness and passing talents with coolness under pressure, something that Heinsohn thought Phillip had gained far afield from the sports arenas.

"He was tough-minded," Heinsohn said. "I think that experience in the Second World War really helped build him as a player. When things weren't going the way you'd like them to go, he was there to help you overcome."